

Principles of Programming Languages

Abstract Syntax

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Outline

Alphabet. Lexical analysis. Parsing.

Parse Trees

Abstract syntax trees

Abstract syntax in Coq: demo

Sentences in a programming language

Which phrases are correct?

- ▶ `int x; x = x + 2`
- ▶ `int x; x = x + 2;`
- ▶ `if (a > 0) then x = 1; else x = -1;`
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Overview: alphabet, lexical analysis, syntax.

- ▶ ***Alphabet*** : set of (allowed) symbols
- ▶ *Lexical analysis*: identify the sequence of symbols constituting the *words* (or *tokens*)
 - ▶ *Lexical rules*
- ▶ *Syntax*: describes which sequences of words constitute “legal” phrases
 - ▶ *Grammars*

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Alphabet

The Alphabet of C from the Standard has 96 symbols:

- ▶ a, b, c, d, e, f, g, h, i, j, k, l, m, n, o, p, q, r, s, t, u, v, w, x, z
- ▶ A, B, C, D, E, F, G, H, I, J, K, L, M, N, O, P, Q, R, S, T, U, V, W, X, Y, Z
- ▶ 0, 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8, 9
- ▶ ! " # % & ' () * + , - . /
- ▶ : ; < = > ? [\] ^ _ { | } ~
- ▶ *Separators*: space, horizontal and vertical tab, form feed, newline

Lexical analysis

Problem: Given a sequence of characters, find the pieces with assigned meaning from that sequence: words or *tokens*

Example:

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- ▶ Output: `if, (, a, >, 0,), then, x, =, 1,;, else, x, =, -1,;`
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Example I - Lexical rules

- ▶ **Integers: 6, 0, -2, +3**
- ▶ The *alphabet* $A = \{+, -\} \cup \mathbb{N}$
- ▶ *Lexical rules*: used to describe atomic language constructions: numbers, identifiers, ...
- ▶ *Lexical rules* are expressed using *regular grammars* (check → Formal Languages, Compilers and Automata course)
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 - ▶ Regex for integers: `[\+-]? \d+`

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Problem: how to combine the tokens in (valid) sentences?

- ▶ Answer: we define the *grammar* of the language
- ▶ Noam Chomsky: *generative grammar*
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- ▶ Language of palindromic strings using symbols a and b
- ▶ The *alphabet* $A = \{a, b\}$
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- ▶ How do we “formally” describe palindromic strings?
 - ▶ Note that there is a simple recursion of a palindromic string
 - ▶ Base: a and b are palindromic strings
 - ▶ Recursion: if s is a palindromic string then so are asa and bsb
- ▶ Examples: “aba”, “aabaa”, “bab”, etc
- ▶ *Problem?* yes: “aa”, “abba”.
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- ▶ **Base case:**

- ▶ $P \rightarrow \epsilon$

- ▶ $P \rightarrow a$

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- ▶ **Recursion:**

- ▶ $P \rightarrow aPa$

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- ▶ **Context-free grammar** (you study this in your compiler course!)

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Backus-Naur Form (BNF)

- ▶ *Meta-language* introduced by Backus and Naur to define ALGOL60
- ▶ Vocabulary:
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BNF - example I

► Palindromic strings:

$P ::= \epsilon \quad (1)$

$\quad | a \quad (2)$

$\quad | b \quad (3)$

$\quad | a P a \quad (4)$

$\quad | b P b \quad (5)$

Derivations

- ▶ How to obtain a *derivation*: read the production as rewrite rules and find a finite sequence of rewrite steps
- ▶ Example: derivation for $abba$
 $P \xrightarrow{4} aPa \xrightarrow{5} abPba \xrightarrow{1} abba$

Parse trees

► Derivation: $P \rightarrow^4 aPa \rightarrow^5 abPba \rightarrow^1 abba$

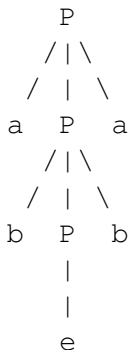
► Parse tree:

► contains nodes labeled with terminals, nonterminals, and ϵ



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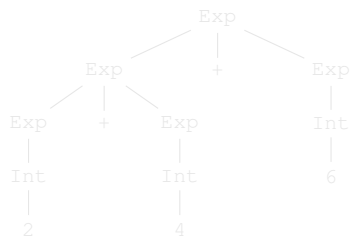
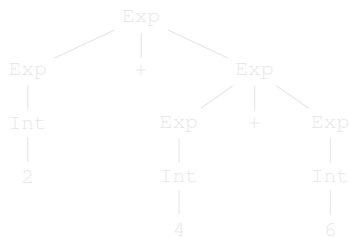
BNF - example II

► Simple expressions language:

```
Int   ::=  [\+-]?[0-9]+
Exp   ::=  Int
        |  Exp "+" Exp
        |  Exp "*" Exp
        |  Exp "/" Exp
        |  "(" Exp ")"
```

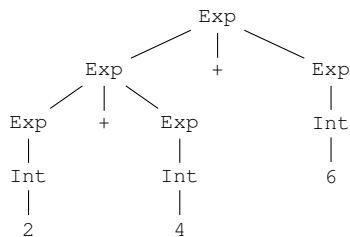
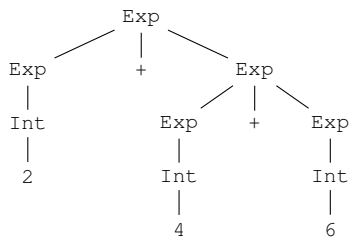
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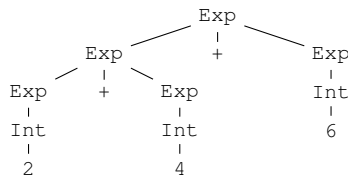
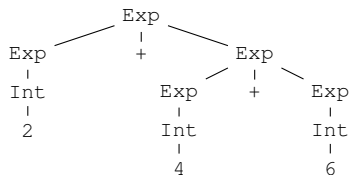


► Solutions?

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- Encode some kind of associativity: **left** or **right**

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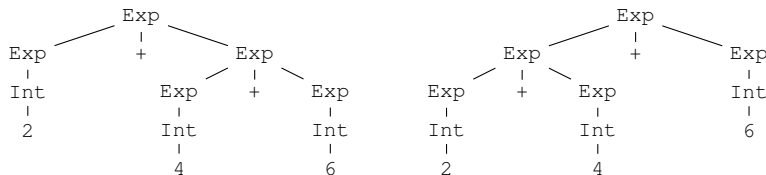


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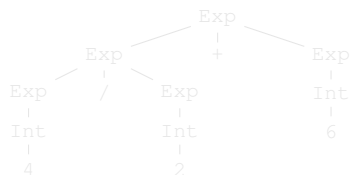


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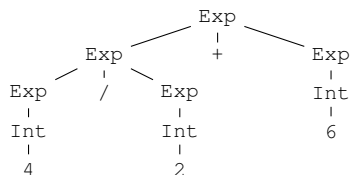
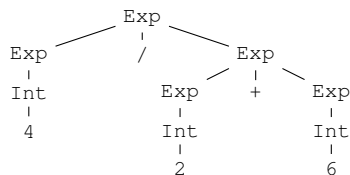
Possible parse trees for $4 / 2 + 6$:



► What parse tree is correct in this case?

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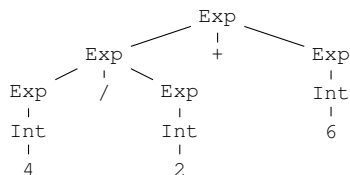
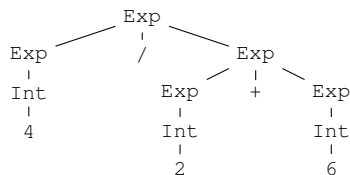
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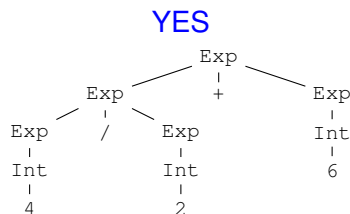
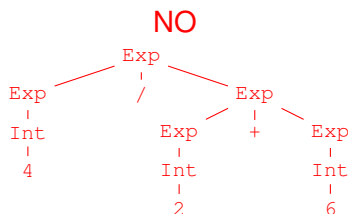
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Solutions:

- ▶ establish priorities between various constructs
- ▶ filtering vs. modify the grammar

Abstract Syntax Trees

- ▶ Grammars define *concrete syntax*
- ▶ Arithmetic expressions:
 - ▶ $1 + 2$ – infix notation
 - ▶ $(+ 1 2)$ – prefix notation
 - ▶ $(1 2 +)$ – postfix notation
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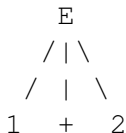
postfix



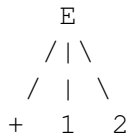
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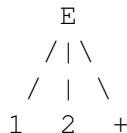
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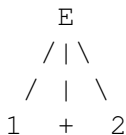
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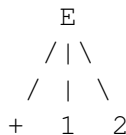
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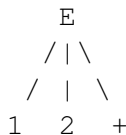
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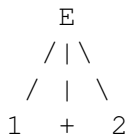
► *abstract* representation of all the above trees:



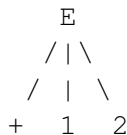
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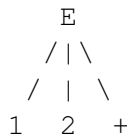
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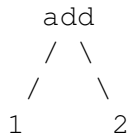
prefix



postfix



- *abstract* representation of all the above trees:

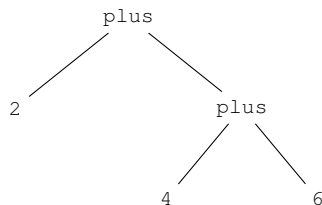


Abstract Syntax Trees

- ▶ Grammars define *concrete syntax*
- ▶ An AST is a *tree* representation of the structure of a program where the syntactical details are ignored
- ▶ For instance, addition has the same abstract tree even if in some languages the syntax is different (e.g., C vs. Haskell)
- ▶ Compilers use ASTs as the main data structure

Example: arithmetic expressions

AST for $2 + (4 + 6)$:



```
Inductive Exp :=  
| number : nat -> Exp  
| plus : Exp -> Exp -> Exp.
```

```
Coercion number : nat >-> Exp.
```

```
Check (plus 2 (plus 4 6)).  
plus 2 (plus 4 6)  
      : Exp
```

Abstract Syntax in Coq

The BNF grammar of arithmetic expressions:

► $E ::= \text{nat} \mid E + E \mid E * E$

The corresponding Coq encoding is:

```
Inductive Exp : Type :=  
  | num : nat -> Exp  
  | plus : Exp -> Exp -> Exp  
  | mul : Exp -> Exp -> Exp.
```

Abstract Syntax in Coq

The BNF grammar of arithmetic expressions:

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```
Inductive Exp : Type :=  
  | num : nat -> Exp  
  | plus : Exp -> Exp -> Exp  
  | mul : Exp -> Exp -> Exp.
```

Coercion

Complicated:

```
Check (plus (num1) (num2)) .
```

Less complicated:

```
Check (plus 1 2) .
```

Coercion

Complicated:

```
Check (plus (num1) (num2)) .
```

Less complicated:

```
Check (plus 1 2) .
```

Notations

```
Inductive AExp :=  
| avar : string -> AExp  
| anum : nat -> AExp  
| aplus : AExp -> AExp -> AExp  
| amul : AExp -> AExp -> AExp.
```

```
Coercion anum : nat >-> AExp.
```

```
Coercion avar : string >-> AExp.
```

```
Notation "A +' B" := (aplus A B)  
      (at level 50, left associativity).
```

```
Notation "A *' B" := (amul A B)  
      (at level 40, left associativity).
```


Demo

- ▶ Arithmetic expressions
- ▶ Boolean expressions
- ▶ Statements

Bibliography

- ▶ Sections 2.1-2.4 from *Programming Languages: Principles and Paradigms*, Maurizio Gabbrielli, Simone Martini; 2010.
Link: http://websrv.dthu.edu.vn/attachments/newsevents/content2415/Programming_Languages_-_Principles_and_Paradigms_thereds1106.pdf